



MONTHLY UPDATE

Connectivity: monthly update, August 2026

Edition of 2026-09-06 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

44 places. Every block below is carried verbatim from that place's own monthly update, where it was written, sourced and checked; nothing is written here.

ALGERIA · ANGOLA · BENIN · BOTSWANA · BURKINA FASO · BURUNDI · CAMEROON · CAPE VERDE ·
CENTRAL AFRICAN REPUBLIC · COMOROS · COTE D'IVOIRE · DJIBOUTI · DR CONGO · EGYPT · EQUATORIAL GUINEA
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SOUTH AFRICA · SOUTH SUDAN · SUDAN · TANZANIA · TOGO · TUNISIA · UGANDA · ZAMBIA · ZIMBABWE

The place reports do not share one window; the period above is the range they span.

Algeria

The one dated position is the licence award rather than any new build. [Three commercial 5G licences were awarded to the three operators in December 2025](#), and that is where the record stands: no coverage obligation, rollout milestone or subscriber figure has followed on this ledger since.

Angola

Two lines moved and neither is national. An operator [installed 20 towers in Cabinda with commercial service days away](#), and the satellite licence application open since 2024 [remains unresolved](#), with no decision published either way.

Benin

The regulator published a competitive ranking. Its weekly readings [placed the state-linked operator Celtiis ahead of MTN and Moov Africa on 3G and 4G data speed](#). The measurement is the regulator's own, the ordering rather than the absolute speeds is what it publishes, and the state's interest in one of the three operators is worth holding in mind while reading it.

Botswana

The [Plumtree-Bulawayo section of a regional fibre corridor went live on 6 July, carrying traffic at 800Gbps equipped on equipment rated over 10Tbps](#), with a second phase to Livingstone due September 2026. The corridor is stated as a Botswana-Zimbabwe-Zambia route; the live section is inside Zimbabwe and no Botswana segment is dated.

The western corridor did produce a Botswana segment. Alongside the Kasane memorandum the two sides disclosed that [MTC has completed the Gobabis-Buitepos fibre link, now interconnecting with BoFiNet at Charles Hill](#) — described as the first direct cross-border fibre link between the two operators — and costed the Trans-Kalahari

Corridor's remaining 4G gaps at about N\$52 million across 13 new sites. The two national incident-response teams are also said to be deepening cooperation. No capacity, commissioning date or traffic figure is published for the fibre link.

Domestic access moved on a much smaller scale. The backbone company [completed its 2025/26 local access projects at P43m, taking fibre to Moshupa, Ramotswa/Taung and Thamaga and connecting 191 customers — 68, 66 and 57 across the three — with 210 construction jobs](#). The customer count is the operator's own and is a count of connections, not of premises passed.

Burkina Faso

At the Prime Minister's mid-year review of 25 July the digital ministry reported 46.7% physical execution of its 2026 objectives contract, the replacement public-administration network's architecture finalised with suppliers' bids under evaluation, and [satellite-operator admission negotiations advancing](#); that operator remains unlicensed.

The regulator ran a four-day workshop with territorial authorities from 29 June to 2 July, naming local opposition and misinformation as continuing brakes on tower rollout. At an address-protocol forum on 3 July the regulator and operators again called for a migration plan with a firm calendar; none is adopted.

The month's one new external route is a proposal rather than a link. Burkinabè and Nigerian digital ministries [met in Ouagadougou on 12 August to explore connecting Nigeria's planned 90,000km open-access fibre backbone into Burkina Faso](#), alongside cooperation on artificial intelligence in local languages, digital public infrastructure, cybersecurity and skills, and [a stated aim of halving internet costs through that backbone](#). No instrument was signed and the Nigerian backbone is itself unbuilt.

Burundi

On 3 August the regulator ARCT [accepted that internet quality is degraded and named the causes](#): recurrent electricity cuts forcing base stations and data centres onto generators the operators struggle to fuel, unstable supply from the utility REGIDESO, bandwidth saturation in urban centres, ageing transmission equipment and simple absence of masts in parts of the country. It said it can apply the sanctions in operators' licence conditions, and named two remedies: a draft law enabling ICT infrastructure sharing and a PAFEN-financed mast-deployment programme. Lumitel and Econet Leo were contacted for that account and did not respond.

On the money side, the universal service fund's [revised FY2026/27 procurement plan carries BIF 11.40bn for dedicated IP transit](#) — 8 Mbit to public health facilities and 10 Mbit to schools — funded from the 1% levy on operator turnover rather than from the general budget.

Cameroon

The regulator's director-general said the [preparatory work for 5G is practically complete but set no date for commercial launch](#), calling for more operator investment. A regulator saying the groundwork is done while naming no date is the whole of the position: no spectrum award, coverage obligation or licence term is on file.

Cape Verde

The regulator's quarterly market series, which had stopped at the second quarter of 2025 in this base, resumed on 5 August with the [first-quarter 2026 report](#): 588,603 active SIM cards at 113.9% penetration, down 0.8% on the quarter, and 511,702 internet access subscriptions, up 1% on the quarter and down 4% on the year. The composition of internet access moved rather than its level — mobile broadband subscriptions fell 16.4% year on year while fixed

broadband rose 12.9%, and 86% of subscriptions are still delivered over mobile broadband on a small screen. Market shares by internet subscription are CVTelecom 72%, Unitel T+ 27.3% and Starlink 0.64%, the satellite operator up 0.20 percentage points on the quarter. The series carries no breakdown by island or municipality.

Central African Republic

The country's dependence on one neighbour was examined. A published assessment [set out the options for reaching submarine cable capacity other than through Cameroon](#). For a landlocked country, the transit route is the bandwidth constraint. The assessment names alternatives; the record held carries no route secured, no agreement signed and no capacity figure.

Comoros

Comores Télécom [revised its retail fibre and mobile offer on 15 July 2026](#), cutting the entry fibre tariff from KMF 32,500 to KMF 30,000 a month while raising the basic allowance from 800 GB to 850 GB and adding unlimited calls to fixed lines. [Director-general Ali Hadji Mmadi also announced eSIM provisioning — KMF 5,000 to migrate an existing SIM, KMF 10,000 for a new one — and two paid value-added SMS services, a pharmacy-on-duty locator and prayer-time notifications](#). The account is the operator's own press event, and its internal dateline is inconsistent: it describes the launch as "yesterday, Monday 15 July," though 15 July 2026 fell on a Wednesday, so the date's precision is flagged uncertain.

The connectivity project the agency carries reached the stage before financing. At a technical meeting on 10 August the [African Development Bank and the Multilateral Cooperation Center for Development Finance told the finance ministry they were ready to fund the feasibility studies as a grant](#), the project covering data-centre studies and inter-island connectivity. No commitment amount, study contract or timetable is stated, so no finance record was built.

Cote d'Ivoire

A low-orbit satellite operator [went live by 17 July](#) at XOF 28,746 a month for residential service, with hardware from XOF 148,148, on a twelve-month provisional licence reviewable on service quality. On 31 July the minister said regional satellite capacity would be routed through the universal-service bodies, with a working session on terms due the following week; no terms, tariff or timetable was stated. No 5G launch occurred against the announced July 2026 date. Ministry figures given on 13 July put telecommunications penetration above 130% of population and [about 38,000 km of optical fibre](#).

On protecting what is already laid, an operator and its vendor [completed a proof of concept in Abidjan that detects vibrations around fibre ducts and classifies them to flag third-party excavation before a cut happens](#), on trials run since 2025. The account is vendor-issued and states no commercial deployment, coverage or date. The cable that carries much of the traffic had already failed and been mended: the [2Africa branch into the country came back into service on 2 August after repairs](#), with WACS repairs expected the week after. Neither the outage's start nor its cause is stated.

An industry survey supplied a fact the base did not hold: 5G has run on re-allocated existing frequencies since a [provisional allocation of 19 December 2023](#), which let the two largest operators offer the service for the 2024 Cup of Nations, and it reached 7 per cent of the population in 2025, used first for fixed broadband where there is no fibre. The definitive spectrum award and the commercial launch announced for July 2026 are still undelivered, so the two things the base had run together are now separable.

The rural programme's own account reached the base for the first time. Its [first phase is complete, commissioned at Djebakaha in Korhogo, with phases two and three launched alongside it - the second valued at FCFA 18bn and covering 240 further localities across Belier, Poro, Tchologo, Bagoue and Haut-Sassandra, against a programme target of 575 localities](#). The account dates that commissioning to August 2024 while reporting it as current, so the phase chronology is not relied on here; no site count, service specification or subscriber figure is published for the completed phase.

Djibouti

On 3 August 2026 the Italian foundation Med-Or reported that a [project promoted by Italy's foreign ministry with Med-Or is building the Djiboutian authorities' capability to inspect and protect the submarine cables](#), under a memorandum with the Ministry of Economy and Finance covering critical infrastructure, digital connectivity and strategic dialogue. [Med-Or's figures put 12 cables landing in Djibouti, six connected to Italy, and about 18% of international submarine cable data transiting the country](#). No amount, term or delivery date is stated and the memorandum is not held.

On 29 July the new communications minister [received Japan's ambassador and the UN resident coordinator in succession](#), covering audiovisual media re-equipment, journalist training against disinformation, and the strategic weight of the cables. No agreement was signed and no figure was given.

DR Congo

Deployment of the transformation project's fibre backbone was reported to the Council on 3 August: [7,000 km laid against more than 18,500 km, leaving 11,500 km outstanding](#) and tied to connecting 145 territories by 2030. The minister attributed the pace to budget constraints and a low disbursement rate on external financing, blamed on donor procedure.

Coverage arrived from orbit before it arrived by fibre. An operator [commercially launched a satellite-to-mobile service on 14 August, the first African operator to take the technology out of testing](#): a compatible LTE Android handset with a clear view of the sky reaches messaging and SMS through satellites where there is no terrestrial network, with no dish, router or other equipment, and the [regulator has confirmed a phased rollout](#). The service is stated as designed for light data, and the only access term published is a [free 30-day trial for customers who register through the operator's app](#); no standing tariff, coverage map or subscriber figure is on the record.

Starlink users in Kinshasa [face four to six months of possible slowdowns while the network is congested](#). No subscriber count, capacity figure or remediation date accompanies the notice.

A cross-border route was reaffirmed rather than started. The Tanzanian and Congolese foreign ministries [agreed to fast-track a fibre-optic cable from Kigoma to Kalemie in Tanganyika province through Lake Tanganyika, alongside a standard gauge railway link through Burundi and the establishment of a joint economic commission](#). The statement came at a farewell meeting for the Congolese ambassador in Dar es Salaam; no route survey, cost, financing, landing point or delivery date is published, and no Congolese ministry statement is on file.

Egypt

An independent measurement published on 3 August 2026 gave the first full-year reading of Egypt's 5G launch. Six months after commercial service began in June 2025, the 5G median download speed had fallen to about 89 Mbps from 110.5 Mbps on launch day, and the combined 4G and 5G median stood at 34.77 Mbps against a pre-launch baseline of 37.68 Mbps ([measurement](#)). Egypt is the only one of the four North African launch markets with no published coverage or quality obligation attached to its award.

Attention has moved to the band above it. The incumbent, the regulator and a Chinese vendor [ran a mobile base station and a data call over upper 6 GHz on 19 August, reported at about 1.7 Gbps per user](#) and stated by the operator as the first such trial in Egypt and in Africa. It is a trial: no allocation, award, licence or commercial date follows it, and the throughput figure is the operator's own.

GSMA Intelligence's country-by-country survey [puts Egyptian 5G take-up at 3 per cent](#) and projects 60 per cent population coverage and 35 per cent take-up by 2030, crediting an early-2026 spectrum agreement with doubling operator capacity.

Equatorial Guinea

Satellite service reached the country. [The operator's own principal confirmed on 29 August that the service is available in Equatorial Guinea](#), after an authorisation earlier in the year that reached only North American companies operating on the high seas within jurisdictional waters. No licence text, tariff, subscriber route or regulator statement accompanies the confirmation, so the base holds a claim of availability and not the terms it is available on.

Eswatini

The one dated position here is a standing statutory right rather than a change. Free adjudication of consumer complaints against communications providers [runs under the Eswatini Communications Commission Act 2013, with windows of one month for post and courier, three for broadcasting and six for telecommunications](#). It is structural provision and not movement: no complaint volume, adjudication count or outcome is published against it.

Ethiopia

The incumbent closed its financial year with [data and internet at 31.1% of revenue against mobile voice at 23.5%](#) — the first year in which voice was not the largest share — on 215.8bn Birr of revenue and 92.9bn Birr of operating profit, the operator's own unaudited figures. Build-out continued underneath it: a progress review on 10 August put [879 sites completed under one vendor programme and 4G population coverage at 92%](#), a figure scoped to that vendor's own footprint and not reconciled against the 95.5% national coverage claimed for the wider contract set. The second licensee reported [14.7 million ninety-day active customers at 30 June](#), against a target of positive earnings by March 2027.

Gabon

On 27 July the Libreville seminar on space communications closed with eleven recommendations, confirming a hybrid fibre and satellite model on [2,000 km of fibre already deployed](#).

The national internet exchange point opened a reboot workshop at Libreville on 3 August, running to 8 August, with the Internet Society and AFRINIC as technical partners ([opening](#)). It [closed on 8 August with certificates presented after six days of peering, security and sovereignty training](#); AFRINIC called for a network of trained ambassadors to carry the skills into firms and administrations, and operator representatives named broader institutional buy-in as the task that remains. No participant number and no post-relaunch member count has been published.

Gambia

The country renumbered its mobile network. [The transition to nine-digit numbers began on 4 September 2026, existing numbers taking a two-digit operator prefix – 87 for Africell, 83 for QCell and 86 for Comium; Gamcel numbers are not affected in this phase and keep their seven digits](#). The numbering plan instrument is not published, and nothing states when the deferred operator joins.

Ghana

The regulator's [consolidated response of 31 July](#) answered sixty written queries from four prospective applicants, formally amended the request for applications in seven places, and shifted every subsequent date by 21 days, with licence fees now due 17 November. [It refused any extension to the 70% population coverage obligation of 6 March 2027 while confirming that obligation is band- and technology-neutral and can be met in substantial part from existing deployment](#). It also rewrote the dominant operator's rural schedule from licence-relative years into fixed dates of December 2029, 2032 and 2035, expressly so that buying spectrum would not accelerate an equivalent existing commitment. [And it recharacterised the 40% premium on that operator's reserve prices in writing as a price for attributable value rather than a sanction or a market-power remedy, declining to publish its valuation model during a live assignment](#).

Beneath the licensing argument, the traffic that never leaves the country was counted. On 16 August the Accra exchange was reported [past 200 Gbps, against three exchanges that barely overlap: only 4 of 39 connected networks peer at all three, so most local traffic still transits abroad](#). The headline figure is the smaller finding. An exchange is worth the traffic it keeps local, and three partly-overlapping exchanges keep less of it than one would.

Guinea

Facebook, YouTube and TikTok became inaccessible on 28 July 2026. The Association des Blogueurs de Guinée activated its monitoring protocol the same morning, ran connectivity tests through the day through independent monitors in Conakry and the interior, and [concluded that the results converge on a targeted block of those three platforms, arguing the precision of the restriction excludes an ordinary outage](#). It grounded its objection in article 19 of the constitution, article 9 of the African Charter and article 19 of the ICCPR.

The restriction [disrupted business operations and online services](#), and was [still running on 7 August, outside any electoral period or declared crisis](#), with WhatsApp also disrupted and VPN traffic passing.

Kenya

The Communications Authority introduced a [Communications Equipment Distributor licence](#) by public notice on 21 July 2026, mandatory before equipment type approval and customs clearance, with penalties of KSh 1m or three years.

Satellite capacity ran out in the country's densest markets. The operator [suspended new sign-ups across seven counties](#) in early July, diverting orders to a deposit-backed waitlist. On 4 August the second mobile operator said its direct-to-cell pilot had completed and it awaits regulatory approval; the interference audit opened in March has produced no published finding.

The government fibre programme was measured against its own deadline for the first time. The ICT Cabinet Secretary put [37,000km installed against the 100,000km target serving 53,000 government facilities, leaving 63,000km outstanding months before the 2027 deadline](#); the programme was announced in November 2022 and split in 2023 into 52,000km for government and 48,000km for private companies, with Sh940.6m paid to the power utility by June 2025. The same account puts [broadband subscriptions at 52.85 million by March 2026 against 22.08 million in June 2020, fixed internet at 2.66 million, 4G population coverage at 73.4% and 5G at 3.04%](#). The 37,000km is the minister's own figure and no route or county breakdown stands behind it.

Kenya and Tanzania [launched a cross-border terrestrial fibre link](#) on 29 July 2026, integrating the Tanzanian backbone with the Mombasa submarine landings. The London Internet Exchange [added a regional cloud provider to its Nairobi hub](#) in July, reaching 55 or more connected networks on combined traffic of 330 Gbps.

The largest procurement in the window is a surveillance build sold as traffic management. The roads authority is out to tender on [Nairobi's Intelligent Transport System Phase II at Ksh10bn, about US\\$83.8m, covering CCTV, e-police monitoring and vehicle-detection systems at 60 junctions on a 30-month design-build contract financed by a South Korean development loan](#), with the bid deadline pushed back two weeks to 19 August. No data-protection authorisation, retention rule or oversight arrangement for the cameras and detection systems is reported, and no award has been made.

An industry survey filled a gap in the record on 5G: commercial networks opened between October 2022 and July 2023, the largest operator [doubled its 5G sites to about 1,700 in 2025](#), and coverage is projected to reach 94 per cent by 2030, helped by rules that let operators refarm existing spectrum. The service is used mainly as an alternative to fibre for connecting homes and businesses.

Lesotho

The incumbent operator [began selling managed satellite connectivity as an enterprise service on 26 August](#). For a landlocked country whose every terrestrial route to the internet crosses South Africa, it is the first international path that does not.

Libya

LPTIC [met Nokia's regional director on 15 July](#) to discuss network modernisation and 5G deployment; no agreement was announced.

On 7 August LTT and ARABSAT [announced a Strategic Partnership Agreement](#) under which ARABSAT will supply High Throughput Satellite capacity on Arabsat-6A at 30.5 degrees east for LTT's existing and future requirements. ARABSAT's chief executive described the agreement as reflecting the institutional relationship with the Libyan International Telecommunications Company, one of ARABSAT's principal shareholders. No contract value, duration, throughput, coverage or service date was published.

Malawi

The communications regulator found both mobile operators in breach of the tariff-notice requirement on 17 July 2026, for failing to publish approved tariff changes seven days ahead; [both agreed to credit affected customers with bundles equal to the price difference and to show compliance by 31 July](#). The approved increase stands.

The ICT minister told Parliament that [additional mobile operator licences are under consideration and that the President had authorised the ministry to find an investor, with spectrum licence fees cut by 50% against the 20% the regulator announced in June 2025](#). No bid timetable, licence terms or spectrum allocation was stated.

The gap the licensing round is meant to close acquired figures in August. An industry association report published ahead of its Malawi summit on 20 August [puts fourth-generation coverage at 87% of the population against mobile-internet penetration of 12.5%, with mobile-money adoption described as near universal, and scores Malawi 36 of 100 on its digital nations and society index and 55 of 100 on policy and regulation](#). These are the association's own figures; no official national subscriber and coverage series is held.

The operator's annual report [puts network infrastructure investment at MK30.87bn in 2025, mainly modernisation, 4G site expansion and 5G](#); the US\$31m the same operator stated in August carried no period and is not reconciled with it.

Mali

On 15 July CSquared [added capacity on the 2Africa West subsea system](#) to the West African backbone whose inland fibre reaches Mali, giving an independent route behind the Abidjan, Accra and Lagos landings.

On 23 July Moov Africa Malitel [announced the retirement of ADSL and migration to FTTH by end-2026](#); no subscriber or coverage figure accompanied it.

On 27 July Maliweb carried a named-analyst investigation into the universal access fund which also [reports AFRIBONE as the sole surviving independent internet provider](#), buying wholesale IP transit at near-retail prices after incumbents allegedly pressed the backbone operator to stop selling dark fibre.

On 30 July the Semaine du Numerique's opening panel [set a universal connectivity target of 2030](#), with the roadmap to be drafted jointly with Burkina Faso and Niger. On 1 August the week's recommendations included [a law making SMTD-SA the sole national operator of transport, transmission, storage and broadcast infrastructure](#).

Mauritania

The regulator's provisional selection for satellite telecommunications licences was [reported on 7 July](#). Thirteen firms took the dossier and nine bids were submitted across two lots. For mobile personal satellite communications, [BRAINSAT at US\\$800,000 and VDM at US\\$50,000 were retained](#), VDM required to align its offer with BRAINSAT's; for the sale of satellite capacity, [BRAINSAT at US\\$3 million and Mattel at MRU 6.5 million](#) were retained on the same condition. No launch date or licence issue is reported, and the operating conditions, licensee obligations and control mechanisms are still to be defined. The account is Agence Ecofin's reading of the regulator's communiqué, which is not held.

The second operator [launched a commercial 5G network at Nouakchott on 10 August under the digital transformation minister](#); no coverage, tariff or subscriber figure accompanies it. The Ministry of Digital Transformation and Administrative Modernisation said on 24 July that [all electronic-communications operators have activated IPv6](#) across their networks and services, and that the national committee monitoring the transition

recorded tangible progress, with one unnamed operator past 15% of subscribers migrated against a 25% end-2026 target. The ministry's stated rationale is sovereignty and security rather than address exhaustion — IPv6 as the precondition for 5G, cloud, internet-of-things and AI services.

Mauritius

The Prime Minister announced on [16 July 2026](#) that [Mauritius will join the America-India Connect subsea cable programme](#). Reporting on [2 August established what sits behind it](#): a signed non-disclosure agreement, terms still under negotiation, no published timetable. The driver is ageing infrastructure — LION and LION2 still carry most international traffic — and the same account notes that Google already operates a ground station at Baie-du-Jacotet serviced by the state operator, so the cable would deepen a relationship rather than open one.

An industry survey put the 5G record on file for the first time: service since July 2021, when the state incumbent opened what the survey calls Africa's first 5G experience zones on spectrum assigned directly to the three operators, [reaching 86 per cent of the population in 2025](#) with take-up projected to move from 9 to 44 per cent. It is delivered mainly as home internet boxes and in shopping centres, business districts and the university.

Connectivity reached the remotest of the Outer Islands by contract if not yet by service. The ICT authority [awarded a two-year contract on 28 August to provide satellite-based internet and communications to Raphael Island in the St Brandon archipelago, a first for the archipelago, with the coast guard, the meteorological services and the island's fishing company as partners](#); no service date, capacity or value is stated.

Morocco

An operator and a vendor placed a dual-band radio configuration into commercial service along the high-speed rail and motorway corridors on 30 July 2026, claiming a 13 dB coverage gain, 83% higher average downlink throughput and 3.2 times the active users with no additional sites built ([deployment account](#)). Every performance figure is the operator's and the vendor's own.

The transitional reduction of mobile interconnection tariff asymmetry took effect on 1 July 2026, running to 31 January 2027, with full symmetry from 1 February 2027, recorded in the incumbent's own half-year filing ([operator filing](#)).

The vendor has since put figures on it: [roughly a kilometre of extra range, an 83% download-speed gain and 3.2 times more concurrent users per site](#), against a regulator count of 19.4m mobile subscriptions and a 34.04% share for the operator at the end of March. The performance gains are the vendor's own.

Mozambique

The incumbent operator's ownership is in play. The government has [formed a technical team to negotiate the sale of part of the state's stake in the loss-making operator](#), which carried a US\$400m debt in 2023, and [set January 2027 as its target for identifying a strategic partner](#). No buyer, share, valuation or treatment of the debt is stated.

The ministry put numbers on how far the connecting has got and how far it is meant to go: [149 localities and 418 schools connected, against a target of at least 300 localities, up to 4,000 schools and around 10,000 new 4G and 5G access points](#). Both ends are the ministry's own and no completion date is given, which leaves a target without a deadline against a rural access rate the regulator itself puts at a quarter of the urban one. On 5G, [a provincial-capital deadline of June 2027 is attached to the spectrum licences](#).

Namibia

Spectrum is being taken back rather than added. Operators [were instructed to retire their 2G and 3G networks and refarm the spectrum, with one suggesting smartphone subsidies before the shutdown](#). A shutdown without a device programme moves the cost of the transition onto the users least able to carry it, and no date, subsidy or handset count is on the record.

The largest mobile operator said it [will put N\\$624.9 million into telecommunications infrastructure in the 2025/26 financial year](#) – a stated commitment rather than a delivered figure.

Niger

On 27 July the telecommunications regulator [opened a second drive-test campaign over Niamey, running to 28 August 2026](#), to verify the corrective actions ordered after the April-May control found voice and mobile-data quality deficient at all four operators, with SMS alone compliant and one operator additionally below the 4G coverage thresholds.

Nigeria

An account published on 29 July puts about [101,000 km of fibre already built](#) and finds that it bypasses some 130m Nigerians – a utilisation and last-mile finding sitting directly against the 90,000 km headline of the national fibre programme.

What is built is being cut faster than it is being protected. The regulator [put fibre-optic cable cuts from road works at more than 5,000 in the first half of 2026 and stood up a standing committee with the works and communications ministries and the National Security Adviser's office](#) to coordinate protection of fibre designated as critical national information infrastructure. No terms of reference, meeting cycle, budget or enforcement power is published for it.

The backbone programme meanwhile looked outward before it broke ground. Nigerian and Burkina Faso digital ministries [met in Ouagadougou on 12 August to explore connecting the planned 90,000 km open-access backbone into Burkina Faso, with a stated aim of halving internet costs through it](#). Nothing was signed, and physical deployment still stands at 2027 on the project documents.

On the tower estate, shareholders of the tower company [approved the acquirer's cash buyout of the 75.3% it does not already own](#), the target's first-half revenue rising 8.2% to US\$844m while rising Nigerian diesel costs and acquisition charges cut operating income 38%. Federal strategic review of the transaction is the last position the base holds on the state's side.

Two build programmes put dates on themselves. The government says resource mobilisation and contracting are complete for [about 3,700 towers to be deployed from October for more than 20 million people in unserved and underserved communities, with the first being installed in Delta State and riverine communities targeted before mid-2027](#); no contract value or supplier is stated. Where fibre does not reach at all, an operator [now runs nearly a dozen light-beam links across Lagos serving banks, hotels, internet providers and a utility, and plans to extend to Abuja, Ibadan and Kano](#). A state airport also [activated a multi-gigabit backbone on 8 August over a commercial submarine-fibre network, to carry passenger processing, operations and real-time security monitoring](#).

The state also went back to orbit, and changed suppliers doing it. The Federal Executive Council [approved the acquisition and deployment of two high-throughput communications satellites, NIGCOMSAT-2A and 2B, to be built by Thales Alenia Space and Israel Aerospace Industries on 22 August, with NIGCOMSAT-2A due by the end of 2028 and 2B in 2029 or 2030 on the operator's own timetable](#). The award [breaks with the Chinese partnership that built](#)

NigComSat-1, which failed in November 2008, and NigComSat-1R, launched in 2011 and approaching the end of its fifteen-year design life, and sits alongside a January 2025 partnership with Eutelsat for low-earth-orbit services. No contract value is published and negotiation with the two manufacturers precedes manufacture.

Beneath all of that the licensed retail-ISP market is a rounding error and is concentrating. Regulator data released on 25 August put active licensed-ISP subscribers at 420,989 in June 2026, up 19.6% from 352,006 in December 2025, with three providers holding close to 70% of the market – Spectranet 111,384, Starlink 98,642 and FibreOne 56,486 – points of presence up from 2,508 to 2,893, and 126 of the 230 licensed ISPs reported to have a single active subscriber. The same data puts that whole market at 0.27% of the country's 156.4 million active internet subscriptions, which is the scale at which any argument about broadband competition here has to be read.

Katsina State began the last-mile stage of its fibre network, the state investment promotion agency coordinating with commercial providers to move from core installation to connections for homes, businesses and public facilities across all 34 local government areas, with right-of-way fees waived and a roadmap target of 2,000-3,000 km of fibre and 70 per cent broadband penetration for which no date is given. The satellite programme got its financing shape: the operator disclosed that NIGCOMSAT-2A and 2B will be vendor-financed and backed by export-import banks, with the amount official only once financing closes.

Lagos put a figure on its own build. The state says it has laid about 3,000km of a planned 6,000km unified fibre network between 2019 and 2025 and plans to secure 200-400MW of state-procured electricity, alongside a claim of more than US\$80bn in commitments to technology development. Both figures are the state's own, given at a trade exhibition, with no route, cost or independent verification published.

Rwanda

The legacy-network retirement plan the ministry announced on 28 July fixes third-generation service off nationwide on 30 June 2027, with operator pilot shutdowns during 2026 and critical-system migration completed in the first half of 2027. December 2028 is the working date for the second-generation network, conditional on coverage, voice reliability including emergency calls, continuity of mobile money, migration of dependent systems and affordable handsets. The technical precondition followed days later: the dominant operator launched voice over fourth-generation networks, reported on 3 August, with no coverage, handset-base or subscriber figure and no reference to the sunset. A subsea operator announced a 25,000 km system across fifteen countries on 9 July with no timeline disclosed; a landlocked country's exposure to it is backhaul rather than a landing. As at 30 July the World Bank's successor nine-year country partnership framework is prepared but not launched, with no committed envelope on the record.

The cross-border route got its operator's own description as the peering forum met in Kigali: a 2,000km protected corridor from Goma to Mombasa connecting Kigali, Kampala and Nairobi, inside a network the operator puts across sixteen African countries. Both figures are the operator's own.

Somalia

Price is Somalia's unusual strength. Mobile data prices were reported among the cheapest in Africa, alongside smartphone financing offers. The record held carries no price-to-income figure, which is the measure that decides affordability; cheap data in a low-income country is not the same as affordable data, and nothing here settles which this is.

South Africa

The [National Radio Frequency Plan 2026](#), approved by the minister on 2 July, was gazetted on 24 July and realigns the allocation table from 8.3kHz to 3,000GHz to the ITU Radio Regulations and to the SADC and African Telecommunications Union plans. The [IMT Roadmap 2026](#) was published for consultation the same day; its tables record 794MHz assigned to licensees and 18,831MHz still to be assigned. The regulator's [accompanying statement of an increase from 850MHz to at least 18,588MHz by 2030, and of a 215% rise in high-demand spectrum](#), does not appear in the gazetted text; the two accounts have not been reconciled. Allocation of the 6GHz band was [deferred pending a feasibility study](#).

Herotel, a domestic provider with more than 350,000 customers, was [named Amazon Leo's South African distributor](#) for a 2027 launch. Starlink [began service in its 27th African country](#) and remains unlicensed in South Africa; the department told Parliament its draft satellite policy direction was ["of general application and not directed at any specific operator"](#). The state-backed [BrainSAT](#) venture launched on Emirati infrastructure. By 20 August the licensing question had produced three separate moves and no decision: the minister [told the International Space Summit Africa that low-earth-orbit services are part of the country's digital future while conceding that licensing is the regulator's call alone](#), which leaves his December directive on equity-equivalency schemes unresolved; Starlink's operator [asked the regulator for flat per-licence spectrum fees, blanket terminal licensing and a ten-year minimum licence term](#), and used the same submission to ask for consolidated guidance on the 30% equity threshold; and Amazon's Kenyan subsidiary [applied for a fifteen-year gateway licence next door](#), which is what building out around an unresolved market looks like.

The month's largest infrastructure fact was not the state's. Comsol [began selling wholesale access to a national 5G-only home-broadband network, with resellers owning the customer relationship and the first ISP due live in September](#), its chief executive accepting the description that this is the wholesale open-access network the state spent more than a decade trying to licence and abandoned. It is privately financed, after Nedbank Private Equity's exit in December, and publishes no coverage footprint, site count or wholesale price, so what has entered service cannot be sized.

Cape Town's municipal planning tribunal [approved two Equinix data centres](#) over objections from three civil-society organisations; the application disclosed neither water nor electricity demand, both deferred to the site development plan. Reuters put the planned load at about 170MW. NTT Data South Africa confirmed it had [sold seven facilities and leased them back](#). Google held its first African cloud summit in Johannesburg and announced an Eastern Cape exchange port; the President welcomed hyperscaler commitments while [stating that government is building its own cloud through the CSIR](#).

One date the state does not have is the oldest. The communications department [told parliament that no date has been set for the analogue television switch-off](#), sixteen years past the original 2010 deadline, with estimates of households still dependent on analogue ranging from about 500,000 on one civil-society account to between 2.2m and 4.5m on two others. The record reconciles none of them, and the absence of a date is now carried as a gap.

South Sudan

Prices rose and the numbers behind them did not appear. The information minister [publicly defended the telecommunications tariff increase on 24 August](#); the regulator maintains it is a revision of the exchange rate used to calculate charges rather than a tariff increase, and neither regulator nor operators have published the revised rates. A cost defended without a price is a position the base can record and a reader cannot check.

Regionally, East African states [opened a joint bank account to fund a feasibility study for a communications satellite, with deposits due by 30 September 2026](#). No contribution figure for this country, study scope or reporting date is stated.

Sudan

Satellite connectivity moved from contested to locally severed. An armed group [ordered every public market in a West Kordofan locality closed and satellite internet services cut off indefinitely from 26 August 2026](#), in a decision reported by a local emergency room which warned that severing satellite connectivity would cut displaced families off from relatives and from incoming remittances in a locality already under deteriorating security and living conditions. The order coincided with reinforcements arriving from Darfur.

Tanzania

The minister inspected the national backbone at Mpwapwa on 24 July. The network stands at about [14,000 km carrying four public data centres and a third landing cable](#); in the region inspected, 942.5 km had been built against 65 people connected. The regional manager stated that phase one connected government offices and public institutions, with individual citizens next. At the same inspection [636 masts were stated due in March 2027, with a second programme of 280 masts under way](#) with no cost, financier or completion date given.

On 29 July the Kenyan and Tanzanian ministers [launched a terrestrial fibre link across the border, integrating the national backbone with submarine cable capacity](#). No capacity, cost or financing was stated, and the base does not reconcile it against the 2025 connection on the route.

A separate tower programme reported its own reach to Parliament on 15 August: a [TZS 126bn, 758-tower project – TZS 55bn from the World Bank and TZS 71bn from the universal service fund – has connected 8.5 million people across 1,400 villages](#), in the same report that records 14,826 data controllers and processors registered with the data protection commission by June 2026. The ministry gives no count of towers completed against the 758 planned, and no measure of service uptake in the villages it says are connected.

The second operator [launched fibre-to-the-home in Dodoma](#), with plans to widen coverage across the city on a stated 300 billion shilling investment.

The month's other route is a border crossing that has not begun. The foreign minister said the two countries would [fast-track a national fibre-optic cable from Kigoma to Kalemie in the Democratic Republic of Congo through Lake Tanganyika, alongside a standard gauge railway link through Burundi and a joint economic commission](#). No route survey, cost, financing, landing point or delivery date is published.

Togo

The Council of Ministers [authorised a five-year renewable licence for Internet-of-Things networks](#) on 4 August, distinct from the incumbent mobile and internet authorisations; the decree authorises the grant rather than recording it, and no licence number, fee, coverage obligation or ownership of the licensee is published. Separately, [capacity was added on a second submarine system for route diversity](#) after three multi-country West African outages in twenty-eight months – a pan-regional arrangement in which Togo is one of eleven places named and no Togo-specific capacity, price or route figure appears.

Tunisia

A measurement study of North African 5G published on [3 August 2026](#), cited rather than absorbed, reports the Tunisian 5G median down 30% from launch by month six and the combined 4G and 5G median below the pre-launch baseline, while fixed-wireless lines rose to 319,554 by May 2026 under the regulator's 30 Mbps obligation. Nothing published bears on the submarine cables, data centres or satellite licensing.

The one physical build to move was a stalled one. The grands projets commission [ordered immediate procurement to complete the Cite Numerique d'Ennahli technology park](#) at a review session chaired by the Prime Minister on 10 August, alongside unrelated power-station and hospital projects. No cost, completion date, occupancy plan or account of why the park was incomplete is stated.

Uganda

The regulator published sector figures on 2 July: [about 47 million active SIM subscriptions and smartphone usage of 20 million devices, up from 18 million](#). The regulator's own quarterly report for the period to 30 September 2025 recorded 45.7 million active mobile subscriptions; both sets are compiled from licensees' submissions.

The second operator reported the same demand from the other side: [19.7 million customers at the half year to 30 June, up 10%, of whom 8.9 million take data, up 18.8%, with data traffic up 42.1% and average use per customer up 21% to 7.2GB against smartphone penetration of 46.6%](#) — its own unaudited figures, and the first half-year series the base holds for it.

On 5 August the network operator with the largest published footprint released its 2025 sustainability report, recording for the year to 31 December 2025 [24.2 million subscribers, population coverage of 96.2% 3G, 88.6% 4G and 19% 5G, 27,037 km of fibre and 45% of network sites on solar or hydro](#). These are the company's own unaudited figures and the base holds no prior-year comparator.

The largest mobile operator [extended its group-level Starlink partnership to Uganda](#) to bring satellite-backed connectivity to remote areas. It is distinct from the satellite operator's own licence, and no coverage target, site count or tariff is given.

Zambia

A government-owned shared 4G network for public institutions was launched at Ndola Teaching Hospital on 15 July 2026, run by the state ICT institute with three named partners and the health ministry ([launch account](#)). The reported outcomes are clinician accounts at the launch site; no baseline or measured result is held.

On 5 August the institute confirmed that connectivity gaps persist at Nakonde, Victoria Falls, Kazungula and Chirundu, and set a single national standard through the government network of tiered 10 to 100 Mbps bandwidth, dual links with automatic failover and enterprise-grade firewalls. A trade facilitation body has commissioned an audit of ICT infrastructure at five border posts; no budget, timetable or completion date is published, and the audit precedes the procurement rather than following it ([status update](#)).

The technology ministry [put the country at about 26.2 million mobile subscriptions in 2025, up from 23.2 million in 2024, with about 14.7 million mobile internet subscriptions](#) - its own figures, given in a seminar address rather than a regulator publication.

A further Northern Province district administration was connected in August, and the account is unusually specific about what a connection reached. After the provincial ICT unit installed connectivity at Lupososhi District Administration and ran a virtual orientation on the national portal and two office collaboration tools, an official [printed a road-tax document from his own office instead of travelling to Kasama for it, days before it expired](#). It is one office and one document: no district count, schedule or cost for the programme is published.

Zimbabwe

Phase 1 of the cross-border fibre corridor from Plumtree to Bulawayo was reported live and carrying traffic on 3 July 2026, at an initial equipped capacity of 800 Gbps on equipment rated above 10 Tbps; phase 2 to Livingstone is due in September 2026 ([corridor account](#)).

The listed infrastructure company reported for the quarter ended May 2026 that it deployed 90 new base stations and reinvested 17% of revenue into capital projects on an undisclosed revenue base ([trading update](#)).

The state fixed operator's chief executive told its annual general meeting on 26 June that government arrears had risen to close to US\$42m, also given as ZiG1.2bn, from US\$19.2m a year earlier ([annual general meeting account](#)). The state mobile operator terminated its chief executive's contract on 4 August following a board resolution ([termination account](#)).

The state incumbent [set a target of connecting 114,000 homes to fibre](#), positioning the offer against satellite and private fibre competitors on price and speed. No timetable, current connection count or tariff accompanies the target.

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